

A look back: Sen. Bob Oke reflects on 16 years in state Senate

By Christopher Britton
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In 1985, at the age of 44, Bob Oke thought his life was winding down. Little did the recently retired Navy veteran realize as he was reeling in a salmon during one of his many fishing trips to Manchester, near Port Orchard, that his true calling in life was about to begin.

Oke's political career actually sputtered to life four years later, after two failed attempts at unseating then-incumbent Rep. Wes Pruitt in 1986 and again in '88. Oke finally was elected to the state Senate in 1990, defeating incumbent Bill Smitherman in a contentious race.

What transpired over the following 16 years would prove to be among the most tumultuous, controversial, and perhaps rewarding periods in Oke's life, culminating in the passage of an anti-tobacco sampling bill protecting children, enjoying the honor of having a Centralia pheasant game farm named after him, and winning a hard-fought victory on the successful passage of the second Tacoma Narrows Bridge project.

In the midst of all of this, he was diagnosed in 2004 with multiple myeloma, a rare form of blood cancer. Despite his initial recovery, the cancer has returned, and he is currently undergoing chemotherapy to fight his illness. Oke, a Republican representing the 26th Legislative District, will not run for re-election this year at the end of his term.

In spite of this latest struggle, Oke still finds the time to actively serve his community. Just hours before this interview, he could be found at Voyager Elementary School visiting with students who wrote him thank-you letters expressing their gratitude for the passage of the anti-tobacco bill.

Oke, his wife, Judy, and their three Brittany spaniels (Abbey, Princess and Isi) spent an afternoon relaxing at their 5-acre homestead in Port Orchard and reflecting back on his 16 years in the Washington State Senate.



Photo by Christopher Britton
Sen. Bob Oke and his wife, Judy.

KP News: What do you consider to be your greatest/proudest achievement while serving in the state Legislature?

Oke: Passage of the bill to end the giving away of free cigarettes and chewing tobacco in Washington state. That was a six-year experience, and it was one of the last bills approved by the House this year. I think this will do more in keeping tobacco products away from our kids than anything else we've been able to do.

KPN: Was this an effort on the part of the tobacco industry to market tobacco products to children?

Oke: What was happening was at that time, some five or six years ago [the tobacco companies] weren't paying any attention to the law because the law wasn't paying any attention to them... Of the 80 percent to 85 percent of smokers that start, start at the age of 17 or less, and they kill 440,000 people every year, so those are the people they have to replace.

KPN: Do you feel like you have any unfinished business in the Legislature?

Oke: Right now, no. I had told them with about a week to go [prior to the close of the 2006 session] that "if you people don't pass that [tobacco] sampling bill, I'm going to run again—which would have been very difficult—and I'm going to win my seat, and then I'm going to go over to campaign against Bill Grant [D-Walla Walla], who's been holding it up for six years."

KPN: If it were possible to go back to any time during your tenure in Olympia, what one thing would you change or do differently?

Oke: That's a difficult one... maybe doing more of visiting schools and the

kids. I enjoyed it, and I think they got a lot out of those visits. They would come down and visit me in Olympia, too, and I always tried to make sure that I gave time to the groups. Sometimes we would be in some critical, critical voting phase and it would be hard to get over and visit with them. But I tried to make it to every group and spend close to a half-hour with them.

KPN: What do see as the Key Peninsula's most pressing issue in the next five to 10 years?

Oke: I think Highway 302. You know what's surprised me in 16 years? To my knowledge, I can't remember anyone asking me to widen or do something with the bridge, the Purdy Bridge. I mean, it's just too narrow. It's like the Tacoma Narrows Bridge... I've been surprised there hasn't been a push for something there, because it's a backup, in fact, we're backing up traffic clear to [State Route] 16 in the evenings now.

It's a dangerous road. We're doing some things to the road, but there needs to be a major improvement. One of the improvements we're hoping to do would be a road a little north from Purdy, which would be a straight shot through to the highway that goes through Shelton. It's on the list of things to do, but there's no money to do it.

On both sides of the [Narrows] bridge we're now spending about \$350 million for the connectors all the way to Nalley-Valley, and then the last piece, we'll pump \$425 million to fix [the Tacoma Dome area]. So we're getting a lot of money and all of that will affect, certainly, the Key Peninsula.

KPN: What was your greatest disappointment?

Oke: Probably back to the sampling [bill], why it took six years. It makes me mad at times. We could have had the bill passed in the first year, we had the votes, and may have saved a lot of young people from getting started.

KPN: What do you consider to be the most significant event (state, national, local, or otherwise) to ever occur during your 16 years in the Legislature?

Oke: For me it's the second Tacoma Narrows Bridge... We received hate mail... Four or five years back, [Penny Drost, a staff member] called one day, and she said, "Bob, I think you and Judy need to give up on this bridge. It's becoming dangerous." When I would go to a meeting in Gig Harbor, the local police would wait for me to escort me to the car... The brochures they put out against me in the two elections were really ugly.

KPN: Have you endorsed anyone in

particular for your position?

Oke: I've endorsed Jim Hines. He's been very active in [promoting Jessica's Law regarding sex offenders]. He would be a good legislator. I think he would do a good job in the Senate. Lois McMahan, my desire is for her to stay in the House. She's familiar with it.

KPN: What do you feel to be the most controversial issue you've dealt with as a lawmaker?

Oke: The second bridge, no question about it.

KPN: Why do you feel it was controversial?

Oke: We had six projects selected by companies all over the world, and the Tacoma Narrows project was the only one that survived... The real thing that killed the other five projects was that the word got out that we were going to charge tolls on existing highways, and that was not true. We were going to charge tolls on new portions of highway, and it's going to happen. We're going to build toll lanes and let people decide if they want to pay more money or wait in line.

KPN: So the controversy was based on the erroneous information that the existing roads would have tolls placed on them?

Oke: Yeah, and the fervor of the people that came to Olympia was awesome. I've never seen one issue get people so stirred up like that particular issue. And the legislators were running scared. They didn't want any part of something so many people were against paying for, but I knew there was no viable option without tolls and I never considered not supporting the second Tacoma Narrows Bridge project.

KPN: Do you plan to participate in public life in the future?

Oke: I've let the governor know that I would enjoy...being on the Fish and Wildlife Commission. There are nine members, and that's really the area that I've focused on so much in my 16 years, is improving hunting and fishing, the quality for outdoor recreation, and state parks. We're losing so much, and there can be tremendous benefits for families and the state in supporting those issues.

KPN: What are your plans after your recovery?

Oke: I like to hear the question like that. I really haven't made any firm plans, because there are very few things that are firm in my life, right now, but Sunday at church we were exposed to lots of local things they are trying to do for people. It's a mentorship program [for kids]. Getting out and sharing my story with others seems to be a benefit